CODEORBIT TECH • CYBER SECURITY INTERNSHIP

PHISHING EMAIL IDENTIFIER

A Practical Email Threat Awareness Report

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Purpose: To demonstrate how common phishing indicators can be identified in sample email messages and to recommend safe steps for handling suspicious emails.

EDUCATIONAL PROJECT • FICTIONAL SAMPLE EMAILS • NO LIVE LINKS

1. Introduction

Phishing is a social-engineering technique in which an attacker impersonates a trusted person or organization to persuade a recipient to disclose sensitive information, open a harmful attachment, visit a deceptive website, or transfer money. Phishing messages may imitate banks, universities, delivery companies, online services, or colleagues.

The goal of this project is to practice recognizing warning signs in email content. The examples in this report are fictional and were created for learning; they are not evidence of real attacks. Text alone cannot conclusively prove whether an email is genuine. Sender details, link destinations, message context, and independent verification should also be considered.

2. Objectives

• Identify common warning signs in suspicious email messages.

• Analyze five fictional email examples and record the indicators present.

• Distinguish between a message that appears suspicious and one that appears more routine.

• Recommend safe actions for verifying, reporting, and handling suspicious messages.

3. Common Phishing Indicators

Indicator	What to look for
Urgency or threats	Pressure to act immediately, such as claims that an account will be blocked.
Suspicious or mismatched links	A link whose destination does not match the claimed organization or expected domain.
Unverified sender	An unfamiliar or misleading sender address, or a sender identity that has not been independently confirmed.
Requests for secrets or payment	Requests for passwords, one-time codes, bank details, gift cards, or unexpected fees.
Unexpected attachments	Files or links that arrive without a clear reason or were not expected.
Unexpected rewards	Prize or refund claims that require a fee or sensitive information.

Important: A single indicator does not automatically prove that a message is phishing. Evaluate the whole message and verify through a trusted channel. Professional spelling and branding do not guarantee safety.

4. Analysis of Five Sample Emails

All examples below are fictional. No live or clickable URLs are included.

Sample 1 — Likely phishing

Subject:	Your account will be blocked!
Sample message:	“Your account will be disabled in 10 minutes. Click the link below and enter your password to restore access.”

Indicators identified

• Creates artificial urgency and threatens account loss.

• Encourages clicking an unverified link.

• Requests a password through an email-linked process.

Assessment: The combination of pressure, an unverified link, and a password request is strongly suspicious.

Recommended action: Do not click the link or provide credentials. Open the official service website by typing its known address or use its official app. Report the message through the service's established process.

Sample 2 — Likely phishing

Subject:	Congratulations! You won a prize.
Sample message:	“You have won a free smartphone. Pay a small processing fee and provide your bank details to claim it.”

Indicators identified

• Unexpected prize claim.

• Requests an advance payment.

• Requests sensitive financial details.

Assessment: An unexpected reward tied to a fee and bank details is a strong warning sign.

Recommended action: Do not pay or provide financial information. Verify any promotion independently through the organization's official website and report the message if appropriate.

Sample 3 — Suspicious; verify independently

Subject:	Urgent: University account verification
Sample message:	“Your student account requires verification today. Sign in through the link provided in this unexpected email.”

Indicators identified

• Unexpected sign-in request.

• Time pressure.

• Link destination and sender have not been verified.

Assessment: This could be a phishing attempt, but the text alone is not enough to establish that conclusively.

Recommended action: Do not use the email link. Visit the university portal through a known address or contact the university IT/help desk using verified contact details.

Sample 4 — Suspicious; verify independently

Subject:	Unpaid delivery fee
Sample message:	“Your parcel is on hold. Open the attached file to confirm your delivery details and pay the outstanding fee.”

Indicators identified

• Unexpected attachment.

• Payment request.

• A delivery problem is used to prompt action.

Assessment: The unexpected attachment and payment demand warrant caution. A legitimate delivery company may sometimes charge fees, so verification is necessary.

Recommended action: Do not open the unexpected attachment. Check tracking through the delivery company's official website or app using a tracking number you already trust.

Sample 5 — No obvious warning sign in the text

Subject:	Reminder: Scheduled class tomorrow
Sample message:	“This is a reminder about tomorrow's scheduled class. Please check the university's official student portal for the timetable.”

Indicators identified

• The message directs the reader to an official portal rather than asking for a password in the email.

• No urgent threat, unexpected reward, payment demand, or attachment is described.

Assessment: Based only on the sample text, this message appears more routine. The sender and context have not been verified, so it cannot be certified as genuine.

Recommended action: If the message is expected, access the student portal through its known address. Check the sender details and report anything inconsistent.

5. Findings Summary

Sample	Classification	Main indicators
1	Likely phishing	Urgency, link, password request
2	Likely phishing	Unexpected prize, fee, bank details
3	Suspicious; verify	Unexpected login, urgency, unverified link
4	Suspicious; verify	Unexpected attachment, fee, pressure
5	No obvious signs in text	Still verify sender and context

6. Phishing Email Safety Checklist

Before responding to an unexpected email, ask:

- ■ Do I recognize the sender, and does the full sender address make sense?
- ■ Was I expecting this message, attachment, invoice, delivery, or prize?
- ■ Does the message pressure me to act immediately or threaten consequences?
- ■ Does the link's destination match the organization it claims to represent?
- ■ Is the message asking for my password, one-time code, bank details, or an unusual payment?
- ■ Can I verify the request through the official app, website, or a trusted contact method?
- ■ Have I avoided opening unexpected attachments or enabling macros?
- ■ Do I know how to report the message to my email provider or organization's IT/security team?

If a message seems suspicious

• Do not click links, open unexpected attachments, reply, or share sensitive information.

• Verify the claim independently using a trusted website, app, or contact number.

• Use the email service's phishing-report function or follow your organization's reporting process.

• If you already entered a password, change it promptly through the genuine service, change it anywhere else it was reused, and enable multifactor authentication. Contact the relevant organization if financial or other sensitive data was shared.

7. Conclusion

This project reviewed five fictional email examples to practice identifying common phishing indicators. Urgent threats, unexpected prizes, unverified links, requests for credentials or payment, and unexpected attachments can all be warning signs. The examples also show why classification should be cautious: a message may look routine while its sender or context remains unverified. The safest approach is to pause, avoid risky interactions, and confirm important requests through a trusted independent channel.

Learning outcome: This exercise strengthened awareness of email-based social engineering and provided a repeatable checklist for assessing suspicious messages. It is an educational review, not an automated email scanner or a guarantee that a message is safe.